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Data-Driven Diversity Strategies: Using Data for Targeted Interventions

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The modern workplace is evolving rapidly, propelled by shifting workforce demographics, technological disruption, and global social equity movements. However, **inclusion remains an elusive goal**, particularly in traditionally male-dominated sectors. As per AON's 'Voice of Women' the largest pan-India study of working women in 2024, despite being motivated and ambitious, many women face workplace discrimination based on gender, age and marital status. They experience microaggressions and career setbacks, particularly after maternity leave. Women who face these biases are 3.5 times more likely to leave their organization in less than one year. Work-life balance, supportive management and career development were the top 3 enablers of success for women and Inequitable pay, limited career progression and work stress were identified as the top detractors.

Supporting the above study, Gender diversity particularly is one of the most pressing challenges in traditionally male-dominated sectors, particularly in infrastructure and energy. While global conversations on Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion (DEI) have grown, the rate of meaningful, systemic change in these industries has lagged. Numerous barriers persist—from unconscious bias and microaggressions to inflexible workplace policies and a lack of visible female leadership.

This paper examines how a legacy infrastructure organization leveraged data as a strategic lever to design, implement, and refine a suite of interventions aimed at increasing female workforce participation, enhancing equity, and fostering inclusive workplace culture. Over a six-year period, these interventions collectively led to a substantial increase in women's representation—from 1% to over 21%—and reductions in attrition rates among female employees, particularly in operational roles.

Introduction

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Through methodical, metrics-based decision-making and people-centric programming, PIL has achieved transformational growth in workforce diversity, particularly in gender inclusion. This paper explores the structured use of internal metrics, external benchmarks, and real-time feedback loops to design targeted interventions, monitor progress, and institutionalize inclusive excellence. From policy revamps and capability-building programs like *Veerangana* to structural tools such as KPI-linked diversity goals and DEI Scorecards, this paper provides a roadmap for sustainable, equitable empowerment across legacy industries.

By adopting a data-driven approach grounded in intersectional insights, the organization demonstrated how measurable DEI impact can be achieved even in sectors historically resistant to change. The findings presented herein offer a transferable model for other companies navigating similar challenges.

Establishing a Baseline

Starting Point: Underrepresentation. When PIL began its DEI journey in 2019:

- Women represented only **1%** of its total workforce (2 employees).
- There were **no women in leadership roles**.
- Gender-specific attrition was unmonitored, and there was no structured feedback from marginalized groups.

This reality mirrored the broader energy sector in India, where women are **76% fewer than men** in the workforce.

Building Targeted Interventions

Setting Metrics for Accountability. PIL embedded DEI into its **organizational KPIs**, tracked via monthly dashboards. This included:

- % of women hired, promoted, and retained.
- Gender pay-gap audit and parity targets.
- Participation rates in Leadership development initiatives by gender.
- DEI engagement levels across roles and genders.

These metrics became **core performance indicators** for leadership, ensuring accountability was shared at every level.

Inclusive Hiring Practices. PIL's recruitment philosophy addressed systemic pipeline challenges:

PIL promotes diversity and inclusion through several initiatives, starting with gender-neutral job descriptions to curb unconscious bias at the hiring stage. Departments with skewed gender ratios have mandated "diversity positions," while resume shortlisting is balanced to ensure equal representation of both genders, focusing purely on skills. Recognizing career breaks as valid life choices, programs like "Second Career Opportunities" support women returning to the workforce.

Further challenging industry stereotypes, women engineers were deployed to operationally intensive sites like compressor stations—a bold move that defied industry stereotypes, backed by customized safety protocols and sensitization workshops for on-site teams.

Translating Strategies into Actions

Listening to the Workforce. Armed with industry insights, PIL initiated structured **engagement surveys, listen hours, and focus groups** to understand the employee experience. Key insights included:

- Career breaks were perceived as capability gaps.
- Microaggressions and unconscious bias were widespread but often unspoken.
- Work-life conflict and insufficient managerial support were leading causes of attrition.
- **Visible female leadership increased confidence and retention**—53% of women said they were more likely to stay if they saw other women in leadership.

This **diagnostic phase established the foundation** for a comprehensive and targeted DEI roadmap.

People Centric Policies. A major breakthrough in PIL's journey was the alignment of **employee life-cycle needs with policy enhancements**, including:

- **Maternity Leave** of 6 months: We at PIL believe parenthood is an important phase in every woman's life and thus, every female employee is eligible for this leave from the DOJ itself. She is entitled to 6 months of maternity leave. Over and above the Maternity Leave a new mother is eligible for 5 days of Child Care Leave post completion of the Maternity Leave. Women employees are eligible for miscarriage leave in unfortunate events of miscarriage.
- **Child Care Leave:** 5 additional days post-maternity.
- **Parenthood Hamper:** Parenthood being an important milestone in the life of employees, PIL celebrates the same with new parents by gifting them a special goodie hamper.
- **Adoption Leave:** The Maternity Act provides women employees 12 weeks of adoption leave from the date of adoption for a child only up to 3 months. At PIL the same can be availed for a child up to 2 years of age. In addition, we provide 28 days for adopting a child of 2-12 years of age. Over and above at PIL adoption leave can be availed by both male and female employees.
- **Creche Reimbursements:** PIL provides creche benefits and reimbursement for employees to enable parents to balance their work and family commitments
- **IVF Coverage:** Included under insurance benefits along with exclusive maternity insurance benefits like- coverage for normal and c-section deliveries.
- **Bereavement and Caregiver Leaves:** PIL provides caregiver, and bereavement leaves under wellbeing benefits thereby extending organization support to employees in a time of need. Also, we encourage our employees to adopt a healthy lifestyle by providing them with Wellbeing Reimbursement allowing them to select and enroll in the fitness activity of their choice. Flexi-working Hours: Enabling life-work integration.
- **Flexi-working hours:** Every individual is trusted to deliver the desired results with flexibility of place & time of work; the flexibility enables employees to shoulder their personal responsibilities while also being productive at their own pace.

- **Periodic Women Listen Hours:** At PIL, one of the key steps towards building an empowered workforce for women is actively listening to their needs and addressing their grievances. We conduct exclusive "Women Focus Listen Hour" sessions, where we engage in focused discussions with women employees to gauge their engagement levels and understand their specific needs. This initiative helps us create a supportive and inclusive environment, ensuring that our policies and practices are aligned with the aspirations and challenges faced by our women employees.

These benefits ensured that inclusion extended **beyond hiring and into workplace equity**.

Flagship Programs: Veerangana and PWN.

Veerangana: Leadership from Within

Veerangana is PIL's flagship experiential learning initiative, launched to support & elevate leadership competencies among women employees. The following were the key initiatives:

- **Develop Leadership Competencies:** Experienced leaders interacted with women employees narrating the tenets of leadership through their life experience.
- **Overcome Unconscious Biases:** Theatre Based Learning intervention highlighting the several unconscious biases around gender, age, generation, educational pedigree, etc. with ways to overcome them.
- **Overcome Superwoman Syndrome:** A special session defining Superwoman Syndrome focusing on what, why, and how of the syndrome including how to overcome it.
- **Lead with Emotional Intelligence:** Training in the essentials of Emotional Intelligence and its role in driving success.
- **Reach New Summits:** Fight the inner fears with the aid of fun activities such as Trek.
- **Handle Personal Finances:** Session on mindful investment by finance experts followed by a need-based individual financial consultation for the employees.
- **Build Your Own Beehive:** Studies indicate Networking is an acquired skill and can be acquired with conscious efforts. We Collaborated with networking expert and image consultant to deliver a workshop on building networking skills (research shows that women are often hesitant to Network, an essential business skill)
- **Handle Conflicts Effectively and Collaborate:** Expert session on breaking myths around conflicts and handling conflicts effectively to drive innovation and create a healthy work environment to all employees.
- **Internal Focused Group Discussions:** Connected with women employees to understand their needs and wants with respect to DEI related policies and benefits at PIL.

PIL believes that DEI is an ongoing journey. Veerangana has laid a strong foundation of empowered diverse workforce, paving a new beginning for a broader and deeper outlook towards inclusion.

"**All on Board**" is a flagship development initiative launched by PIL in FY 2023–24, designed to strengthen diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) across the workplace. The program comprises a series of structured training sessions and engagement activities that encourage employees to reflect on and practice inclusive behaviors. Key focus areas include exploring the role of empathy in fostering an equitable work culture, building awareness around unconscious biases and strategies to mitigate them, and recognizing as well as effectively addressing micro-aggressions in daily interactions. By equipping employees with these critical insights and skills, "All on Board" aims to cultivate a more respectful, supportive, and inclusive organizational environment.

Pipeline Women's Network (PWN)



Launched in September 2024, PWN is an internal community built to connect women across roles and hierarchies. It promotes inclusion, collaboration, solution-building, and safe communication channels. PWN's workshops such as "Building Your Own Beehive" and "Her Voice, Her Story" have enabled women to share challenges, seek inspiration, and develop action-oriented growth paths.

Through this network, we aim to:

- Promote Inclusion: Advocate for a culture that is free from biases and rooted in inclusivity.
- Foster Collaboration: Build meaningful, supportive connections across the organization that help both personal and professional growth.
- Seek Solutions: Tackle challenges collectively by leveraging the diverse perspectives and expertise within the group.
- Enhance Communication: Create a safe space where women feel confident in sharing ideas, concerns, and challenges.

We firmly believe that by coming together and supporting each other, we can build a stronger, more inclusive workplace where everyone can succeed.

Various enterprises under PWN continue to amplify **internal voices** and create **external visibility**.

We continued the PWN journey in 2025 in March for International Women's Day with a plethora of events like:

- Inspiring stories of #SHEROs & #HEROs via digital platforms,
- Full-day stalls at the workplace by women entrepreneurs.
- A powerful movie screening
- An experiential workshop themed "Accelerate Actions". The session used the "Wheel of Life" coaching tool, where participants reflected where they are in each area of life and what they want, diving deeper into reflecting what could potentially come in the way of them achieving their goals, emphasizing upon both external barriers and internal resistances, various ways in which we can manifest, the meaning of affirmations, and some common mistakes we end up making while creating affirmations and designing their very own vision boards, with step-by-step guidance

We sustained this development in August with a workshop on **RISE: Reflect, Inspire, Strengthen, Express**. This program was designed to help individuals reflect on and identify internal barriers, harness personal belief to move forward, navigate emotions through tools like self-awareness, expression, and self-talk, and build the ability to deliver and solicit effective feedback for continuous growth.

As we continue to nurture the PWN community, we are committed to rolling out additional initiatives that will further strengthen our inclusive work culture. Our ongoing efforts will demonstrate our dedication to growth, connection, and well-being, ensuring that every member of PWN feels supported and empowered to thrive.

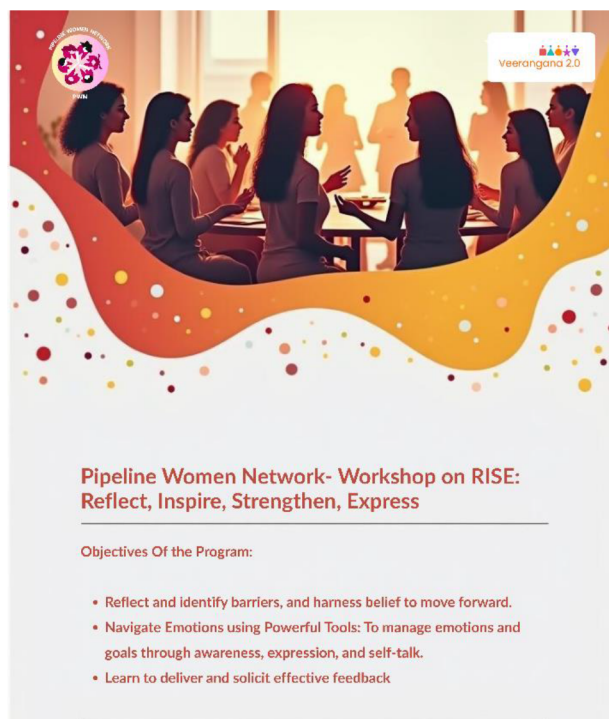


PIL CELEBRATES INTERNATIONAL WOMEN'S DAY 2025

#ACCELERATE ACTIONS

DATE	ACTIVITY	TARGET AUDIENCE	VENUE & TIME
06-12	#SHERDES & #HERDES	ALL EMPLOYEES	ON VIBE
06	WOMEN ENTREPRENEURS STALL	ALL EMPLOYEES	PIL HQ, 11:00 AM TO 05:00 PM
07	PWN WORKSHOP - ACCELERATE ACTIONS	WOMEN EMPLOYEES	TAJ-VIVANTA, TURBHE 9:00 AM TO 03:00 PM
07	MOVIE SCREENING	ALL EMPLOYEES	PIL HQ, 04:00 PM TO 06:00 PM

STAY TUNED FOR MORE UPDATES



Pipeline Women Network- Workshop on RISE: Reflect, Inspire, Strengthen, Express

Objectives Of the Program:

- Reflect and identify barriers, and harness belief to move forward.
- Navigate Emotions using Powerful Tools: To manage emotions and goals through awareness, expression, and self-talk.
- Learn to deliver and solicit effective feedback

Veerangana 2.0

The Veerangana initiative has evolved into Veerangana 2.0 with categorized focus areas — **Embed, Empower, and Elevate** — each designed to provide progressive support for women at different stages of their careers.



The ventures designed under these:



Focus Area	Initiative	Description	Audience
Embed	TGIF: "Beyond the Blocks"	Curtain raiser of Veerangana 2.0	All Employees
Embed	Bias Awareness & Mitigation Workshop	Focused Workshop on: Unconscious Biases in workplace	People Managers
Embed	Psychological Safety & Inclusive Communication	Focused Workshop on: a. Handling dissent respectfully b. Encouraging quieter voices c. Avoiding exclusionary language d. Microaggressions: Spot it, stop it, shift it	People Managers
Embed	Leading Across Generations and Genders	Focused Workshop on: a. Generational expectations and stereotypes b. Gender-inclusive leadership styles	People Managers



Focus Area	Initiative	Description	Audience
Empower	PWN Session- Leading from Within	a. Barriers and Beliefs b. Navigating Emotions using Powerful Tools c. Power of Self Talk	All Women Employees
Empower	Communication & Influence	LinkedIn Learning: a. Confident Speaking & Presentation Skills b. Stakeholder Management for Women Professionals c. Having assertive conversation	Junior Women Employees
Empower	Digital Campaigns: "21 Days of Inclusion"	Digital Learning Campaign	All Employees
Empower	SheSpeaks: Storytelling & Confidence Series	Focused Workshop on: a. Build self-advocacy b. Develop storytelling and articulation skills c. Networking and Connecting with ease	Junior Women Employees
Empower	Self-Leadership & Mindset	Focused Workshop on: a. Growth Mindset & Resilience	Junior Women Employees

Focus Area	Initiative	Description	Audience
		b. Managing Imposter Syndrome c. Time Management & Boundary Setting	
Empower	Women@Work Learning Hub	Articles on Women Inclusion, success stories & Inclusion practices on WhatsApp	All Women Employees



Focus Area	Initiative	Description	Audience
Elevate	Leadership Coaching Lab	Leadership coaching for select women employees	Women Employees (FLL Band)
Elevate	Executive Presence & Influence Lab	Focused Workshop on: a. Strategic & Difficult communication b. Leading cross-functional teams c. Executive decision-making	Women Employees (FLL Band)
Elevate	Allyship Roundtables with Male Leaders	Curated roundtables where male leaders and senior women discuss real challenges and co-create solutions to build shared accountability.	Women Employees (FLL Band)
Elevate	Visibility Accelerator	Intentional nomination of women for external forums (panels, awards, industry roundtables)	Women Employees (FLL Band)
Elevate	Virtual Spotlight Series: "Her Voice, Her Story"	Format: Monthly live or recorded interviews Participants: Women employees across levels share journeys, challenges, and triumphs Purpose: Visibility, inspiration, and storytelling Platform: Vibe & WhatsApp	All Women Employees
Elevate	PWN- My Unique Strength	Peer Learning session- from PIL women employees and external speaker	All Women Employees

Shifting the Culture: Leadership, Allyship and Awareness. Cultural transformation at PIL is driven by inclusive leadership and structured DEI awareness campaigns. Visible female leaders inspire confidence and reduce perceived prejudice, as evidenced by 53% of women reporting higher growth perception in companies with female leadership.

Key indicators from the AON Voice of Women study and internal feedback have shaped DEI sessions addressing:

- Microaggressions and insensitive behaviours (reported by 1 in 3 women).
- Career setbacks post maternity (36% reported impact).

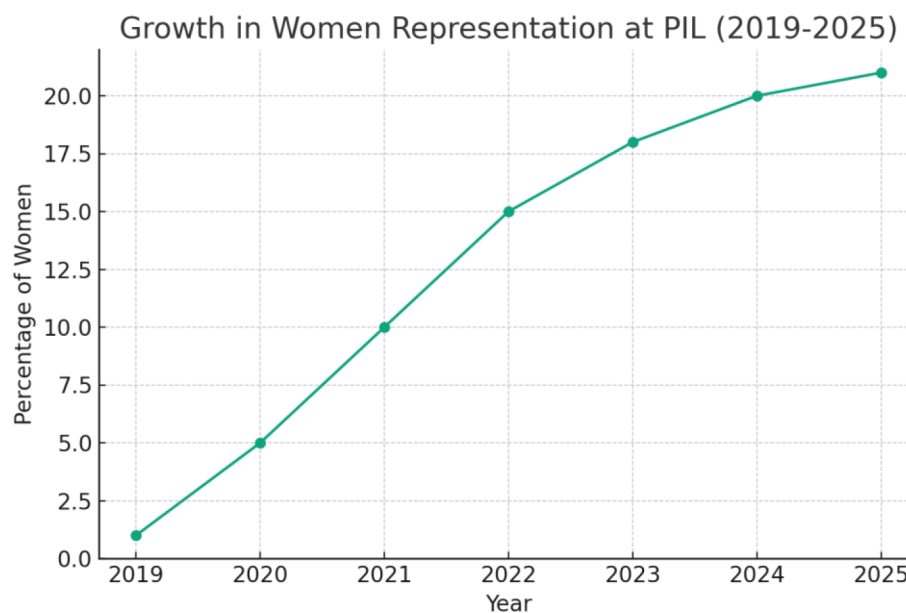
- High domestic burden (64% of responsibilities borne by women).
- Mental exhaustion (81% of women feel mentally fatigued).

Supportive managers play a critical role in improving engagement and reducing attrition.

Impact: Measurable Outcomes

Representation.

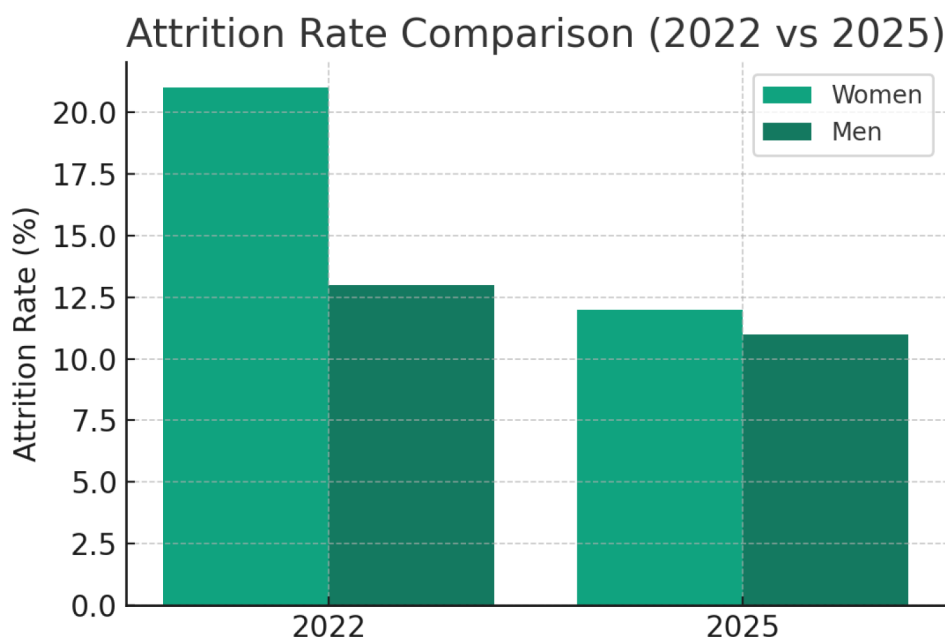
Metric	2019	2025
% Women in Workforce	1%	21%
% Women in Leadership	0%	15%
Women at Sites	0%	Present across compressor stations



Compared to an industry average of 13.9%, PIL exceeded expectations by **institutionalizing field-level gender inclusion**.

Attrition and Retention.

- **Voluntary Attrition (Women):** **Dropped from 21% in 2022 to 12% in 2025.**
- **Post-Maternity Return:** Increased to **74%**
- **Retention Drivers:** Career support, flexible policies, and visible leadership.



Development and Promotions.

- **65%** of eligible women were promoted or moved into complex roles
- **30%** of internal promotions in 2025 were women
- **40%** of women participated in technical programs (vs. 8% in 2019)

Pay Equity.

- **Gender Pay Gap:** 9%
- **Annual Adjustments:** 85% complete

PIL commissioned a **compensation benchmarking audit with Aon Hewitt in 2023**, realigning pay to ensure top-quartile parity.

Culture and Engagement.

- **87%** of employees engaged in inclusion training
- **1,500+** hours of bias and psychological safety sessions conducted
- **100%** leadership trained in inclusive leadership
- **83%** of women reported "feeling heard" in 2025 (up from 42% in 2019)

Person with Disability (PwD) Hiring. Our inaugural hiring of a Person with Disability (PwD) marks a significant milestone in our (DEI) journey underscores our dedication to breaking barriers and creating opportunities for all individuals, regardless of physical abilities.

Discussion

Strategic Use of Data. The data-driven approach enabled precision targeting gaps in recruitment, retention, and development. Disaggregated data allowed tailored interventions across life-cycle stages. Quarterly

dashboards provided transparency and real-time course correction—demonstrating what Hunt et al. (2021) and Catalyst (2022) describe as critical success factors for sustainable DEI transformation.

Structural Reform as a Catalyst. Flexible work, inclusive benefits, and re-entry support for mothers transformed career continuity for women. These reforms aligned with research that links policy flexibility to improved retention and productivity in underrepresented groups (ILO, 2020).

Embed–Empower–Elevate Framework. The three-phase framework ensured cultural shifts occurred in tandem with skill-building and leadership access. Cultural transformation began with awareness (bias training), matured through empowerment (coaching and mentorship), and culminated in sponsorship and visibility.

Challenging Sector Norms. Perhaps most significantly, the case challenges the assumption that DEI progress is inherently slow in legacy industries. This initiative proves that with committed leadership, data accountability, and cross-level engagement, systemic inclusion is not only feasible but replicable.

Learnings and Best Practices

Equity vs Equality. PIL's interventions prove that **equal treatment isn't enough** in skewed systems. The **emphasis on equity**—through tailored benefits, contextual programs, and affirmative hiring—created meaningful impact.

Leadership Buy-In Is Critical. The inclusion of **diversity KPIs in leadership scorecards** reinforced DEI as a business imperative. Male leaders were engaged as **allies through roundtables**, workshops, and visibility campaigns, amplifying their role in the change narrative.

Feedback as a Compass. Initiatives like **Women Listen Hours**, **Pulse Surveys**, and **exit interviews** created feedback loops that informed policy and program iterations.

Conclusion and Recommendations

This case study provides a replicable roadmap for data-informed DEI transformation. Over six years, the organization achieved substantial increases in women's representation and retention, closed attrition gaps, and enhanced leadership readiness.

Key Recommendations.

1. **Establish Baseline Audits and Dashboards** – Begin with disaggregated data and build real-time DEI tracking systems.
2. **Tie Leadership KPIs to DEI Outcomes** – Drive top-down accountability through performance-linked incentives.
3. **Support Structural Inclusion** – Policies must address real-world barriers, including flexibility, caregiving, and mobility.
4. **Develop Talent Through Empowerment** – Invest in skills, mentoring, and visibility for marginalized groups.
5. **Foster Belonging** – Cultural inclusion is essential for retention. Psychological safety, voice, and dialogue platforms are key.
6. **Commit to Continuous Learning** – DEI must be iterative. Feedback loops, audits, and recalibrations are critical.

PIL's journey—from a **1% to 21% female workforce**, from **zero to 15% women leaders**, and from **symbolic to systemic inclusion**—serves as a **blueprint for traditional industries** grappling with DEI transformation.

At the heart of this transformation is **data**: not merely to diagnose, but to **dismantle barriers, drive accountability, and design interventions** that meet people where they are.

By embedding DEI into its DNA—through metrics, mentorship, and mindset shifts—PIL has demonstrated that even industries built on rigid foundations can evolve into **inclusive, future-ready workplaces**

Future Research. While data facilitated precision in intervention, it also revealed **structural gaps**—especially in mid-senior leadership and mentorship availability. However, these gaps have become **clear targets for future investment**.

Further research could extend this model to other sectors, explore intersectionality beyond gender, or analyze long-term leadership pipeline impacts.